PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #49 · ANXIETY

"One small problem will turn into a disaster."

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Where it often comes from

Catastrophizing is anxiety's shortcut. A strange noise, a mistake at work, a child's cough, a bill, or a cool tone in someone's voice is treated as the first step of a chain that ends in ruin. Sometimes a small problem did grow, so the mind now refuses to let any problem stay small. The habit feels like realism. It spends a large fear on a small fact, and then the fear itself becomes the emergency.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus will not let tomorrow's trouble invade today. "Today has enough trouble of its own." Worry cannot add an hour to your life. God says do not fear, for He is with you, and He upholds you. He is a refuge and strength, a help in trouble, which means trouble can be met without being crowned as disaster. Prayer is offered instead of anxiety. A small problem may need a small response. It does not need a tragic ending written in advance.

> *"Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Today has enough trouble of its own"* (Matthew 6:34).

Also see

> "Who of you by worrying can add a single hour to his life?" (Matthew 6:27).

> "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness" (Isaiah 41:10).

> "God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble" (Psalm 46:1).

> "Be anxious for nothing, but in everything, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus" (Philippians 4:6–7).

Common self-statements

- This is how it starts. It always ends badly.
- If I do not treat this as serious, I will be sorry.
- A small leak means the house is coming down.
- I cannot tell the difference anymore.
- People who stay calm are not paying attention.
- One mistake will cost me everything.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Building a disaster out of a limited fact.
- Fortune telling: Writing the tragic ending before the middle of the story.
- Overgeneralization: Because one problem once grew, every problem will.
- Magnification: Making a small issue so large it hides the real size.

Challenging questions

- What is the fact, in one sentence, with no ending attached?

- What are two ordinary explanations besides the disastrous one?
- If this stayed the size it is today, what would I do?
- Have I predicted ruin from a small start and been wrong?
- What would "enough response" look like, short of panic?
- What does Jesus say about taking on tomorrow's trouble today?

Truth summary

> A small problem is still a small problem. I do not have to turn it into a catastrophe. I can take the next step.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

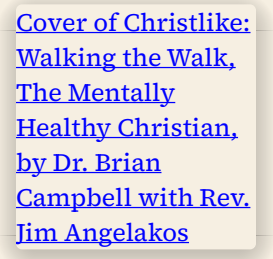
- Anxiety/Worry
- Fear
- Thinking, Healthy
- Peace
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Thinking, Healthy
- Trouble/Hardship

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Even If — MercyMe
A hard outcome would not mean God has left, and most small problems never become that.

Glorious Unfolding — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's story is larger than the small trouble in front of you.

More Than Conquerors — Steven Curtis Chapman
You are not at the mercy of every snowballing fear.

Victory in Jesus — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
Christ's rescue is bigger than a problem that feels like it must ruin everything.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "One small problem will turn into a disaster."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"One small problem will turn into a disaster." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is the fact, in one sentence, with no ending attached?
- ☐ What are two ordinary explanations besides the disastrous one?
- ☐ If this stayed the size it is today, what would I do?
- ☐ Have I predicted ruin from a small start and been wrong?
- ☐ What would "enough response" look like, short of panic?
- ☐ What does Jesus say about taking on tomorrow's trouble today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ A small problem is still a small problem. I do not have to turn it into a catastrophe. I can take the next step.
- ☐ I can respond to what is actually here.
- ☐ Most chains I imagine never happen.
- ☐ God is with me if a problem grows, and it may not grow.
- ☐ Worry will not add an hour of safety.
- ☐ I can fix, wait, or ask for help without calling it ruin.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Matthew 6:34
  "Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Today has enough trouble of its own."
- ☐ Matthew 6:27
  "Who of you by worrying can add a single hour to his life?"
- ☐ Isaiah 41:10
  "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When a small thing felt huge: Each day, write down one moment when a small problem turned into a disaster in your mind. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Matthew 6:34 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Today's trouble is enough. I will not borrow a disaster from tomorrow.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Thinking, Healthy" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Write three endings. For one current worry, write a mild ending, a medium ending, and the disaster. Circle the one with the most evidence, not the loudest.
- [ ] Match the response to the size. Do the small thing the problem actually needs, then stop.
- [ ] Collect false alarms. Note one small worry this week that did not become a disaster.
- [ ] Pray Matthew 6:34 before you expand a problem in your mind.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "One small problem will turn into a disaster.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A small problem that stayed small
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~One small problem will turn into a disaster~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I turn small things into ruin before they have a chance to stay small. Give me a steady mind. Help me do what today actually requires, and leave tomorrow with You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.